

Carlos Alcaraz shown as: 6-1, 6-7 (6), 1-6, 6-3, 4-6. Try to unravel that monstrosity. The score should appear as the far more readable and understandable 1-6, 7-6 (6), 6-1, 3-6, 6-4. Just as NBA teams don't lose games 108-115 or La Liga teams don't lose contests 2-4, tennis players at every level don't lose matches 4-6, 5-7. The proper score — whether written or spoken — is 6-4, 7-5.

Lack of detail in scoreboards — BJ Miller, an astute tennis observer from Oakland, California, contributed this pet peeve along with the remedy. "Major League Baseball and National Football League's on-screen scoreboards show a multitude of relevant stats and facts. In sharp contrast, tennis' on-screen scoreboards sometimes don't even give the players' last names, only the first three letters. They should show serve speeds, seeding, nationality [not with flags], and, ideally, number of winners, forced errors, aces, and unforced errors. The information that occasionally shows up on screen now is too complicated — 3D charts where viewers must sort out whether a player's data is by line or column before being able to compare between players, all in too short a time to even follow the announcer's explanation. The on-screen scoreboard should be in the upper left, not the lower left corner where it obscures important features of the match."

Incomplete scores — TV networks that do not put the entire score during a match on the screen. Instead, they display the number of sets won by each player and the game score of only the set in progress. Viewers need to know the full score to understand the course and context of the match.

Caps or visors indoors — Besides looking silly indoors, caps and visors provide no function. Mats Wilander

Shock therapy: Upsets — major and minor — occur every day at every level in tennis. But a player must embrace the underdog status — as 18-year-old qualifier Emma Raducanu did when she won the 2021 US Open. GETTY IMAGES

also pointed out that baseball caps partly hide the faces of players, citing four-time major champion Iga Swiatek. Part of the appeal of tennis is that we can clearly see the players' emotions, something much harder to do in ice hockey and American football.

Obsession with player boxes — Is it necessary or desirable for *ESPN*, *Tennis Channel*, and other TV networks to turn their cameras on player boxes during matches so often? We see the player's family and friends cringe or cheer after points, especially big points, and their coaches, psychologists, and trainers shout advice. But when coach Brad Gilbert talked too much during the US Open, champion Coco Gauff mildly criticised him afterwards. Occasionally, members of 'the team' even argue with each other, as have the parents of Stefanos Tsitsipas. This soap opera stuff is interesting up to a point, but too much gets distracting and annoying.

Overweight players — I lose interest in and respect for players who don't get into and stay in tip-top shape. Criticism of overweight professional athletes is not 'body shaming,' as some apologists like Zina Garrison claim. It's justified, and TV tennis commentators should do it more often with neither fear nor favour.

Tennis commentator's use of 'underrated' to describe a player or a player's stroke — There is a modicum of plausibility to this overused adjective when players are low-ranked, but otherwise, it's seldom justified. Also, the clear implication is that the commentator is the smartest guy in the room, and other analysts just haven't quite

figured out how excellent this player or stroke actually is. When *ESPN* analyst Pam Shriver once countered this 'overrated' assertion with "Who is underrating him?" she received no answer from her offending colleague, and I had to say "Hooray!" Shriver was saying what I had been thinking for years.

Sore losers — They never give their winning opponent credit for their good or even excellent performance. Instead, it's all about them. These sore losers come up with all manner of excuses, from the nasty to the absurd. Serena Williams used to say she played only 20 percent of her ability and that the real Serena didn't show up. We should look at how 24-time major winner, Novak Djokovic, one of the most emotional champions in tennis history, graciously handles defeat, no matter how big the upset or how prestigious the tournament.

Distracting chatter by TV tennis commentators — *Tennis Channel Plus*, the worst culprit, uses a split screen with one half showing a live match and the other one showing commentators talking about all sorts of tennis trivia, players, and events—anything but the match going on, which is hard to view anyway because it is on a half-screen.

Other channels have 'talking heads' who blabber ad nauseam about themselves even when it doesn't relate to the match and the players they're broadcasting. Early in the TV career of the late Vitas Gerulaitis, he memorably said, "No one cares what I did 15 years ago." A bit of an overstatement, but the 1977 Australian Open champion had a valid point.



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